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Haggai

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Haggai

A. Overview and Summary.

1. The author of the book is Haggai the prophet. He is one of the 12 minor prophets at the end of the Old Testament. It is the word of the Lord as given to Zerubbabel, the governor and to Shealtiel, the high priest (Vs. 1:1). The book was written about 520 BC when the Jews had returned from their 70 years of captivity in Babylon. The Medio-Persian empire had conquered Babylon in 539 BC, and in the second year of king Darius the Mede, those Jews who desired to return to Israel, were allowed to do so. Nothing is known of Haggai outside of this book of two chapters. Haggai is mentioned in only one other book of the Bible, Ezra 5:1 and 6:14.
2. The Jews had returned to Israel and had begun to rebuild the temple of Jerusalem. But due to opposition of the Samaritans, work had stopped, as detailed in the book of Ezra, under the direction of king Ahasuerus, who succeeded Darius. Key verses are summarized below.

B. Chapter 1.

1. Haggai brings God's desire to rebuild the temple before the people: "Is it a time for you yourselves to dwell in your paneled houses, while this house lies in ruins?" (Vs.1:4) He goes on to describe how the Jews efforts at agriculture and other domestic efforts have failed due to their neglect of rebuilding the temple: "Now, therefore, thus says the LORD of hosts: Consider your ways. You have sown much, and harvested little. You eat, but you never have enough; you drink, but you never have your fill. You clothe yourselves, but no one is warm. And he who earns wages does so to put them into a bag with holes" (Vs. 1:5-6).
2. The leaders listen to God's word through Haggai: "Then Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, and Joshua the son of Jehozadak, the high priest, with all the remnant of the people, obeyed the voice of the LORD their God, and the words of Haggai the prophet, as the LORD their God had sent him. And the people feared the LORD" (VS.1:12). The people then came and worked upon the temple.

C. Chapter 2.

1. The construction continues but it is a shadow of its former glory. Haggai speaks to Zerubbabel, words from the Lord: “Who is left among you who saw this house in its former glory? How do you see it now? Is it not as nothing in your eyes? Yet now be strong, O Zerubbabel, declares the LORD. Be strong, O Joshua, son of Jehozadak, the high priest. Be strong, all you people of the land, declares the LORD. Work, for I am with you, declares the LORD of hosts, according to the covenant that I made with you when you came out of Egypt. My Spirit remains in your midst. Fear not” (vs. 2:3-5). The Lord’s words then affirm that the temple and its riches will once more be great.
2. Haggai then brings the word of the Lord to the priests regarding the failure of the people to follow God’s law. But then, he then speaks a blessing from the Lord upon the people: “I struck you and all the products of your toil with blight and with mildew and with hail, yet you did not turn to me, declares the LORD. Consider from this day onward, from the twenty-fourth day of the ninth month. Since the day that the foundation of the LORD’s temple was laid, consider: Is the seed yet in the barn? Indeed, the vine, the fig tree, the pomegranate, and the olive tree have yielded nothing. But from this day on I will bless you” (Vs. 2:17-19).
3. The book concludes with the Lord’s words to Zerubbabel. They are prophetic, as they describe God’s judgement upon mankind at the time of the day of the Lord. They also describe Zerubbabel as a foreshadowing of Christ using a distinctive Messianic term of “my servant”: “Speak to Zerubbabel, governor of Judah, saying, I am about to shake the heavens and the earth, and to overthrow the throne of kingdoms. I am about to destroy the strength of the kingdoms of the nations, and overthrow the chariots and their riders. And the horses and their riders shall go down, every one by the sword of his brother. On that day, declares the LORD of hosts, I will take you, O Zerubbabel my servant, the son of Shealtiel, declares the LORD, and make you like a signet ring, for I have chosen you, declares the LORD of hosts” (Vs. 2:21-23).

D. Discussion, Application and Passing it on.

The Jews had returned to the land of Israel from Babylon with great hope, worshiping God and trusting in His promises. But due to opposition of the local people and a change in government of Persia, work of the temple was halted for 15 years. The people focused on their own houses and domestic efforts, but without success. Haggai’s mission from the Lord was to turn their focus back to His work.

Have you experienced frustration in your life that may have changed your focus from God's priorities of building His kingdom to something else? What are you going to change? Are you able to share insights from the book of Haggai to another believer as an encouragement to them based upon God's unfailing promises?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)